

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Data Analytics and Business Intelligence English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For data analysts, BI developers, analytics engineers, data scientists, reporting teams, business analysts, and data-driven managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

access control

Rules and mechanisms that determine who may use information or a system.

assumption

Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

business definition

An agreed explanation of what a measure or term means in an organization.

causation

A relationship in which a change in one factor produces a change in another.

completeness

The extent to which required information or records are present.

confidence interval

An interval produced by a method with a stated long-run coverage rate under its assumptions.

confounder

A factor related to both a proposed cause and outcome that can distort their apparent relationship.

correlation

A statistical association between variables; it does not by itself establish causation.

dashboard

Visual summary of selected measures used to monitor status, performance, or risk.

data governance

The responsibilities and rules for managing data quality, access, use, and protection.

data model

A representation of how data is structured and how its elements relate.

data quality

How well data meets requirements for its intended use, such as accuracy and completeness.

drill-down

Moving from a summary measure to more detailed information behind it.

effect size

A measure of the magnitude of a difference or relationship.

freshness

How recently data reflects events in the source system.

grain

What one row or record represents in a dataset.

guardrail

A boundary or protective check used to prevent an unacceptable outcome.

insight

An interpretation of evidence that improves understanding of a question or decision.

join logic

The rules used to connect records from different data tables.

KPI

Key performance indicator used to monitor progress against an important objective.

metric

A defined quantitative measure used to track or assess something.

next best action

The action judged most useful for a stated objective given current information.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

pipeline

A sequence of stages through which data, work, or sales opportunities move.

privacy

The appropriate handling of personal information and individuals' related interests and rights.

recommendation

A proposed action supported by reasons and relevant evidence.

retention

Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

sample size

The number of independent units or observations included in a defined analysis.

selection bias

Distortion caused by how people or observations are selected into a study or dataset.

source of truth

The agreed authoritative reference for a particular item of organizational information.

SQL

Structured Query Language: a language for querying and working with relational data.

threshold

A defined value or condition that triggers a decision or changes a classification.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Metric Definitions and Business Questions

Two teams report different active-user totals. One counts logins; the other counts completed transactions.

What action qualifies a user as active, and over what period? The two totals use different definitions. Let's agree on the business question and label each measure clearly.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Data Quality and Trust

A dashboard refreshed today, but one source table contains data only through Monday. A manager assumes all figures are current.

The dashboard refreshed today, but that table is current only through Monday. I'll show the source's data cutoff separately from the dashboard refresh time.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Dashboards and Executive Reporting

A KPI card shows a monthly total without its target, comparison period, or definition. The reader cannot interpret whether the result is favorable.

The total needs context. I'll add the definition, reporting period, and relevant comparison so the reader can understand what changed and whether action is needed.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Causation, Correlation, and Caveats

Customers who attend training renew more often. Attendance was voluntary, and the groups may differ in motivation.

Training attendance is associated with renewal in this dataset. That does not establish causation; the groups may differ in other ways. I'll state the finding with that limitation.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | SQL, Models, and Transformation Logic

A report joins order rows to several payment rows per order. Revenue appears larger after the join.

What does one row represent in each table? The join may repeat order values when there are multiple payments. Let's check the grain and aggregation before interpreting the total.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Experiment Readouts and Statistical Thinking

An experiment estimates a positive effect, but the interval includes values close to no change. The slide presents only the point estimate.

I'll show the estimated effect and its uncertainty together. The point estimate alone hides the range of values compatible with the analysis and can make the result sound more certain than it is.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Data Governance and Privacy

An analyst wants customer-level data but has not specified which fields are needed or how long they will be retained.

Could you define the analysis purpose, necessary fields, and retention period? That will let the appropriate team review access and privacy requirements before the data is shared.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Insight Storytelling and Recommendations

A report lists ten findings but no recommended action. The audience has five minutes to decide whether to investigate a service issue.

I'll lead with the finding relevant to that decision, explain its limitation, and recommend a specific investigation. The other findings can support the discussion without obscuring the request.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Data Analytics and Business Intelligence English

Professional audience: data analysts, BI developers, analytics engineers, data scientists, reporting teams, business analysts, and data-driven managers

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Metric Definitions and Business Questions

Original fictional case: Two teams report different active-user totals. One counts logins; the other counts completed transactions.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: metric: A defined quantitative measure used to track or assess something. / business definition: An agreed explanation of what a measure or term means in an organization. / source of truth: The agreed authoritative reference for a particular item of organizational information. / owner: Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What action qualifies a user as active, and over what period? The two totals use different definitions. Let's agree on the business question and label each measure clearly.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level